

you through the history of Bombay from 1668 when the population was barely 10,000 to 1947 when the streets had to be converted into one-ways to handle the crowds celebrating Independence, you do get the feeling that the future of the city is going to be a mix of emotional upheavals, political shenanigans and high jinks.

The photographs in this section of the book are focused around the people who shaped this city: businessmen such as Premchand Roychand, artists like Raja Ravi Verma and statesmen of the calibre of Justice Badruddin Tayabjee, a former president of the Indian National Congress. These are followed by a series of pictures of Horniman Circle, the first railway track, Apollo Bunder etc, clearly showing a Bombay with its seven islands that could not be contained by the sea: everything between the islands and around them would be reclaimed and consumed over the years.

Fernandes, who is the editor-in-chief of *Time Out* India, has his ancestral roots in Bombay, and writes about the Mumbai of today, knows the city is psychotic, loveable, tough, creepy and cool. He also knows that the orthodox view of Mumbai, as the city of hope, is now a flawed one. He narrates the story of contemporary Mumbai with patience, insight and equanimity. On the Richter scale of urban anguish Fernandes and photo editor and researcher Chaudhuri hit a low zero. This is not a book about the hipsterati that cement the reputation of Mumbai. Nor is it the annoying image of a decaying rogue city drawn by cynics. Instead, the book is a neat document of the forces that have been shaping the city. And looked at one way, it is urban art in progress.

The pictures in this section are about rushed Bollywood, urban agglomeration, jerry rigged homes, business multiplicity, and not-an-inch-to-spare emotions. The pages contain the usual suspects: Bal Thackeray, Amitabh Bachchan and the Ambanis. There are some incongruous images too of sailboats and parasailers in the bay, a stunned leopard lying on the street and a few once-in-a-life-time images that may not necessarily reflect Mumbai (example, the return of the Indian Twenty20 World Champion team in 2007). But these can easily be ignored for the rich tapestry the other images spin of a city that is injudiciously choking with its own brilliance and enterprise.

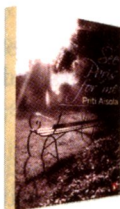
The roughly 240 pages of images have been assembled from a variety of sources—independent photographers, newspaper archives, photo agencies, private collections and museums—to create a visual history of Mumbai that is rich, textured, evocative and rarely gloomy. But perhaps inexorably—and naturally—the words and pictures have undeniable traces of tiredness, exhaustion, fatigue and despair.

And yet, Mumbai continues to build its reputation as a lodestone for the creative, the hungry, the ambitious and even the odd terrorist. It has always been difficult to explain this dichotomy. But could the future of a great city like Mumbai hold anything other than inexplicable duality? ■

Passionately in Paris

This compelling narrative of failed love is infused with poetry and philosophy

| By Geeta Doctor |



SEE PARIS FOR ME
by PRITI AISOLA
Penguin
Price: Rs 299
Pages: 290

Obsession is back in fashion. First there was Orhan Pamuk dancing the Bossa Nova on the Bosphorus, inventorying his hero's eight-year itch. Now there's Priti Aisola, who has followed in the footsteps of earlier writers such as Françoise Sagan (*Bonjour Tristesse*), and writing of the sadness of a failed love that does not quite become an affair, despite living in the quartier, for such liaisons—Paris.

Aisola's heroine is called Sadhavi. As her name suggests, renunciation is a part of Sadhavi's attraction. In the rarefied atmosphere of a highly intellectualised set of Indian groupies, for which read professionals, living in Paris, she meets Kanav, a suave Indian scholar who mingles references to Ananda Coomaraswamy and French existentialists while lusting after the frail, pale, must we say it aloud, Brahminical Sadhavi. It's difficult not to feel a sense of deep disquiet that a new generation of writers, while setting out to explore the contours of their characters in a new world order that calls itself global does so with all the baggage of the past. Aisola drags, indeed glories, in every one of the cultural tags, caste names, food habits, details about clothing, child rearing trends, films and spiritual icons to create what she describes as her heroine's "inner world". The way in which she depicts the other Indian women in her circle, for instance Revathi, with her "earthy brown complexion and rich curly black hair in a loose braid" who "captivated people by her warm dark eyes and lips that itched to break into a brilliant smile or burst into a merry laugh..." is enough to make one gag, right from the start.

For all that, there is still something compelling about the narrative. It's because like the earlier Indian writers like Raja Rao, who confront Indian philosophical ideas with their sense of isolation in the West, Aisola is a deeply sincere observer. She may just be sharing her inner confusions, but in doing so, she infuses her heroine's life with moments of poetry, or with footnotes about writers that we may have relegated to some dusty space, as also news about the world, such as Tsunami-related images, that show she cares.

Then of course, there's Paris, bread, museums and the Metro, always good for a girl in a whirl. ■